



MIXED FARMING

If cattle or sheep are kept on an enclosed field, they eat the grass and drop manure that fertilizes the ground. The farmer can then plow the field and use the fertilized soil to grow crops, while the animals graze another field. After the crops are harvested, the animals can be brought back while the second field is sown with crops. Organic farming is still based on this method, which does not use farm chemicals.



INDUSTRIAL FARMING

Many farmers use artificial fertilizers instead of grazing animals on the land. This allows them to specialize in growing profitable crops, such as wheat, in large fields that can be harvested by large machines. But planting just a few crops can increase the risk of pests, diseases, and weeds, so these industrialized farms use a lot of chemical pesticides and weed killers. Over time, the soil can also become less healthy, and in serious cases it may turn to dust and blow away.



◀ GREENHOUSE

If they are grown under glass, crops such as tomatoes can be produced all year round, even in cool or dry climates.

FARMING UNDER COVER

Some animals and many crops can be raised under cover. This allows more food to be produced in a smaller area, and also enables farmers to grow tender plants that would not survive outside. However, many people think that the intensive rearing of animals such as pigs and chickens is cruel. They also worry about the level of harmful pesticides that may be used on fruits and vegetables grown under glass.

▲ WHEAT PRAIRIE

A huge combine harvester reaps a vast field of wheat in the American Midwest.

SELECTIVE BREEDING

Only the most basic farming uses species of animals and plants that are the same as those found in the wild. Most farm animals and crops are created by selecting the best examples and breeding them to ensure useful features such as better milk yield in cows, or size and flavor in fruits and vegetables. Selective breeding is also used to make crops more resistant to frost or disease, and has hugely boosted productivity.



▲ BRED FOR BEEF

The muscular Charolais cattle have been selectively bred for their high-quality beef.